Country Profile: Latvia

- Number of groups in country: 6
- Plurality religion: Protestantism
- Official language: Standard Latvian
- Official religion: None
- Core group: Latvians

Historical Background

Latvia first declared its independence in 1920. During World War II, Baltic states came under the USSR's sphere of influence and in 1940, Latvia became the Latvian Soviet Socialist Republic (SSR). In the late 1980s, amid Gorbachev's Glasnost and Perestroika reforms, demands for Latvian independence and anti-Soviet protests grew. A major step toward independence occurred on May 4, 1990, when the Latvian SSR Supreme Council, elected in the first democratic elections since the 1930s, adopted a declaration of independence. This declaration initiated a transition period from Soviet autonomy to full independence.

However, in January 1991, pro-Soviet forces attempted to reassert control through military action. Latvian demonstrators successfully resisted. On August 21, 1991, after the failure of a coup attempt in Moscow, the Latvian parliament voted to end the transition period and fully restore the country's pre-World War II independence. The Soviet Union formally recognized Latvian independence on September 6, 1991.

Groups

- **Latvians**, the core ethnic group of Latvia, have played a crucial role in nation-building since the country's independence in 1991. In 1989, Latvians made up 52% of the population, a proportion that gradually increased to 63% by 2021. The Latvian macrolanguage, which includes Standard Latvian and Latgalian, is central to their identity. While Standard Latvian is the official state language, Latgalian is spoken by around 200,000 Latvians. Latvia's religious landscape is diverse, with about half of Latvians identifying as non-religious, and the rest either Lutheran or Roman Catholic.

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- **Russians** are the largest minority group in Latvia. Although they have been present in the country for centuries, a significant influx occurred during the Soviet period due to high migration from the Russian Soviet Federative Socialist Republic. In the final census before independence, in 1989, Russians made up 34% of the population, a figure that had declined to 24% by 2021. Russian is the primary language of identity of the group and serves as a language of wider communication in Latvia. Most Russians in Latvia adhere to the Russian Orthodox faith, represented by the Latvian Orthodox Church in Latvia.
- **Belarusians** in Latvia are primarily concentrated in areas near the Latvian-Belarusian border. Similar to the influx of Russians, the Soviet period saw a significant migration of Belarusians to Latvia. Today, they make up around 3% of the population. Due to limited promotion and education in the Belarusian language, most Belarusians in Latvia today are Russian speakers. They are predominantly Eastern Orthodox Christians, which is closely connected to the Russian Orthodox Church.
- **Lithuanians** are a small minority in Latvia, constituting about 1.5% of the total population. Historically concentrated near the Latvia-Lithuania border, they are now spread throughout the country. They speak Lithuanian, and the majority follow the Roman Catholic faith.
- **Poles** in Latvia primarily reside in cities such as Riga and Daugavpils, making up about 2% of the total population. They speak Polish and predominantly adhere to Roman Catholicism.
- **Ukrainians** make up about 2.2% of Latvia's population. Their history in Latvia parallels that of Russians and Belarusians: small communities were present for centuries, but there was a significant influx during the Soviet period. Although the use of Ukrainian is more common among Ukrainians compared to Belarusian among Belarusians, most Ukrainians use Russian for practical purposes. Ukrainians in Latvia are predominantly Eastern Orthodox Christians, represented by the Latvian Orthodox Church in Latvia.

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State Profile

Official Language

The original 1922 Constitution, reinstated in 1991, did not designate an official state language, but Standard Latvian was used as the de facto national language. Its official status as the state language was established by Article 4 of the 1998 Constitutional amendments.

Official Religion

There is no official religion in Latvia. The separation of Church and State was first introduced in the 1991 Constitutional Law on Human and Citizens' Rights and Obligations. In 1998, this law was incorporated into the Constitution of Latvia.

Education Policies

Latvia inherited a de facto segregated education system from the Soviet era, with two types of schools: those using Russian as the language of instruction, with some Latvian, and Latvian schools, where Russian was taught as a mandatory subject. The parallel structure continued until 1995, when educational reform began to build a unified system, transitioning from separate public schools (Latvian, Russian, Belarusian, Polish, etc.) to a bilingual education system. Schooling in Latvia is divided into three stages: primary education (grades 1 to 4), lower secondary education (grades 5 to 9), and upper secondary education (grades 10 to 12). Private schools face no restrictions regarding the language of instruction, with official regulations established by the Educational Act of 1998.

Language Education Policies

During the Soviet period, Latvia had parallel education systems with Latvian-language and Russian-language tracks. After regaining independence, Latvia extended the right for ethnic minorities, aside from Russians, to receive education in their native languages, including Polish, Ukrainian, Belarusian, and Lithuanian. Latvian was mandated in all educational institutions, regardless of the primary language of instruction. Lithuanian education began with the opening of the first school on September 1, 1991. The first Polish school was established in 1989, Belarusian education saw its only school created in 1994, and Ukrainian education commenced with the first school in 1991.

The 1995 Educational Reform aimed to create a unified system, transitioning from separate public schools (Latvian, Russian, Belarusian, Polish, etc.) to a bilingual

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education framework. The reform was implemented in three stages: the first stage (1995–1999) introduced two subjects taught in Latvian for grades 1 to 9. The second stage (1999–2004) increased the number of subjects taught in Latvian to three for grades 10 to 12. The third stage, starting in 2004, adopted a 60/40 standard, with 60% of education conducted in Latvian and 40% in minority languages.

Private schools can choose their language of instruction freely, as regulated by the Educational Act of 1998.

Religious Education Policies

Although Latvia has no state religion, agreements with eight religious organizations (Evangelical Lutheran, Roman Catholic, Christian Orthodox, Old Believer, Methodist, Baptist, Seventh-day Adventist churches, and the Jewish religious community) facilitate cooperation and the provision of religious education. The 1998 Education Act guarantees freedom of conscience by allowing students to choose between Christian religious instruction, ethics, or both. Government-funded religious and ethics classes are mandatory for grades 1–3, subject to parental approval for specific religious groups. If there is insufficient enrollment, students receive general ethics instruction. Minority-run public schools may offer voluntary religion classes relevant to their community, while nontraditional religious groups can provide religious education only in private schools.

Bans and Restrictions

According to Article 1 of Latvia's Law on the Press and Other Media (1990), freedom of expression is guaranteed, and censorship is prohibited. Both print and electronic media can operate in any language, although state-owned media must adhere to specific language requirements. Minority languages, especially Russian, have a significant presence in print media, with numerous Russian-language newspapers. Other minority groups, such as Belarusians, Ukrainians, and Poles, have access to cultural or religious magazines with smaller circulations. Since 1999, Latvia has enforced language restrictions on naming, mandating that place names, institution names, and event names within the country must be created and used exclusively in the official language, except under specific legal exemptions. Additionally, regulations stipulate that personal names should follow Latvian language traditions. One manifestation of this restriction is the addition of the letter "s" to the end of non-Latvian male names and surnames.

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Constitutions and Laws

In 1991, Latvia annulled the 1978 Constitution of the Latvian SSR and reinstated the 1922 Constitution. The Constitution lacked provisions on state language, religious liberties, or minority rights. In 1998, the government significantly amended the constitution by incorporating the 1991 Constitutional Law on Human and Citizens' Rights and Obligations into the original 1922 Constitution. This effectively transformed it into the de facto Constitution of Latvia, although it is still formally referred to as the 1922 Constitution. The 1998 amendments introduced provisions on fundamental human rights, religious liberties, and the separation of church and state.

In 2014, a comprehensive preamble was added, highlighting Latvia's historical multinational character while affirming the titular status of Latvians as the core group. The preamble thus states: "The State of Latvia, proclaimed on November 18, 1918, has been established by uniting historical Latvian lands and based on the unwavering will of the Latvian nation to have its own State and its inalienable right of self-determination to guarantee the existence and development of the Latvian nation, its language, and culture throughout the centuries."

Citizenship Laws

Latvia's citizenship policies adhered to the principle of *ex iniuria ius non oritur*, which grants automatic citizenship to pre-Soviet citizens and their descendants while creating a "non-citizen" category for Soviet-era settlers. From 1991 to 1993, the October 15, 1991 Resolution on the Renewal of the Republic of Latvia's Citizens' Rights granted citizenship to individuals who were Latvian citizens on June 17, 1940 and their descendants, provided they had lived in Latvia and registered by July 1, 1992. This resolution also aimed to simplify naturalization for those who resided in Latvia on June 17, 1940 but lacked Latvian citizenship. However, due to stringent requirements, naturalization under this resolution did not take place.

The Citizenship Law of 1994, based on the *ius sanguinis* principle, expanded citizenship categories while maintaining the "non-citizens" status for former USSR residents in Latvia. It introduced a "window system" for gradual naturalization, which marked the end of exclusionary policies for Lithuanians and Poles. However, the 1995 Former USSR

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Citizens Act formally established the "non-citizens" category, restricting their rights, including political participation, access to certain professions, and land ownership.[1]

Between 1998 and 2013, significant changes were made to Latvia's citizenship policies. The 1998 amendments abolished the "window system" and provided citizenship to children born in Latvia after August 21, 1991 if they were considered stateless or non-citizens. These reforms aimed to better integrate non-citizen children into Latvian society by simplifying the process and requirements for acquiring citizenship. As a result, the 1998 amendments are seen as ending the exclusionary citizenship policies that had disproportionally affected Russians, Ukrainians, and Belarusians.

From 2013, Latvia's citizenship policy was further simplified to allow children born to non-citizen or stateless parents to be recognized as Latvian citizens if at least one parent expressed this desire at the time of birth registration. Additional provisions allowed for the acquisition of citizenship under various circumstances, such as when one parent was deceased or unknown. Minors applying for citizenship between the ages of 15 and 18 were required to demonstrate language proficiency and have no serious criminal record.

National Anthem(s)

"Dievs, svētī Latviju!" (God, Bless Latvia) serves as the national anthem of the Latvian Republic. It was first adopted as the national anthem in 1920 but was abolished during the Soviet period. The anthem was re-adopted in 1990 when Latvia regained its independence. Written in Latvian, it specifically refers to the Latvian ethnic group, mentions the national territory, and includes explicit religious references.

[1] These discriminatory provisions affected Russians, Ukrainians, and Belarusians and are considered as restrictions (differences) on the naturalization procedure in the NBP dataset.

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